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Measures of length in the Old Testament

11.4.1 Measures of length in the Old Testament

Finger

11.4.1.1 Finger

References:

Hebrew אֶצְבַּע (’etsba‘) JER 52:21

JER 52:21: In this verse some common-language translations render the literal expression “four fingers” (RSV) as “three inches” (GNT), “seven centimeters” (SPCL), “eight centimeters” (GECLFRCLDUCL), or even “five centimeters” (Portuguese common language version). Older and more formal translations retain the “four fingers” of the original, and this is even done by some common-language versions (ITCLNOB). It seems likely that giving the thickness of the Temple columns as “four fingers” will communicate to the modern reader just as graphically as it did to the ancient one.

Palm

11.4.1.2 Palm

References:

Hebrew טֶפַח (tefach) 1KI 7:26, 2CH 4:5

Hebrew טֹפַח (tofach) EXO 25:25, EXO 37:12, EZK 40:5, EZK 40:43, EZK 43:13

Hebrew טַפְחָה (tafchah) PSA 39:6

The *tefach* / *tofach* is the width of the hand at the base of the fingers, not including the thumb.

EXO 25:25; EXO 37:12; 1KI 7:26; 2CH 4:5: In many languages it will be possible to express these words as the Hebrew does, as the width of a hand. Otherwise a measurement such as “8 centimeters” (FRCL) or “3 inches” (GNT) will do. For some reason CEV and NCV have “three inches” in the Exodus references but “four inches” in 1 Kings and 2 Chronicles.

EZK 40:5; EZK 43:13: Here the cubit is said to be longer by one *tofach*. This is the measure used throughout chapters 40–48 of Ezekiel. The shorter cubit actually measured about 45 centimeters (18 inches), and this longer one would have been 53 centimeters (21 inches). Some translations try to reflect the difference. Many, however, will prefer to use a rounded-off value of 50 centimeters (18 inches) for both.

PSA 39:6: Here the word *tefach* (*tapchah*) is a symbolic figure indicating the shortness of life. This may be the basis for the statement of Jesus in MAT 6:27. See the discussion under *pēchus* below.

Span

11.4.1.3 Span

References:

Hebrew זֶרֶת (zereth) EXO 28:16, EXO 28:16, EXO 39:9, EXO 39:9, 1SA 17:4, ISA 40:12, EZK 43:13

With the fingers spread, the *zereth* is the distance from the tip of the thumb to the tip of the little finger.

ISA 40:12: The picture here is of a person stretching out his fingers and using the distance between his thumb and little finger to measure the extent of the sky. For the second clause in this verse, GECL has “Who can … determine the extent of the sky with the span of his hand.”

Cubit

11.4.1.4 Cubit

References:

Hebrew אַמָּה (’amah) GEN 6:15, GEN 6:15, GEN 6:15, GEN 6:16, GEN 7:20, EXO 25:10, EXO 25:10, EXO 25:10, EXO 25:17, EXO 25:17, EXO 25:23, EXO 25:23, EXO 25:23, EXO 26:2, EXO 26:2, EXO 26:8, EXO 26:8, EXO 26:13, EXO 26:13, EXO 26:16, EXO 26:16, EXO 26:16, EXO 27:1, EXO 27:1, EXO 27:1, EXO 27:9, EXO 27:12, EXO 27:13, EXO 27:14, EXO 27:16, EXO 27:18, EXO 27:18, EXO 30:2, EXO 30:2, EXO 30:2, EXO 36:9, EXO 36:9, EXO 36:15, EXO 36:15, EXO 36:21, EXO 36:21, EXO 36:21, EXO 37:1, EXO 37:1, EXO 37:1, EXO 37:6, EXO 37:6, EXO 37:10, EXO 37:10, EXO 37:10, EXO 37:25, EXO 37:25, EXO 37:25, EXO 38:1, EXO 38:1, EXO 38:1, EXO 38:9, EXO 38:11, EXO 38:12, EXO 38:13, EXO 38:14, EXO 38:15, EXO 38:18, EXO 38:18, NUM 11:31, NUM 35:4, NUM 35:5, NUM 35:5, NUM 35:5, NUM 35:5, DEU 3:11, DEU 3:11, DEU 3:11, JOS 3:4, 1SA 17:4, 2SA 2:24, 2SA 8:1, 1KI 6:2, 1KI 6:2, 1KI 6:3, 1KI 6:3, 1KI 6:6, 1KI 6:6, 1KI 6:6, 1KI 6:10, 1KI 6:16, 1KI 6:17, 1KI 6:20, 1KI 6:20, 1KI 6:20, 1KI 6:23, 1KI 6:24, 1KI 6:24, 1KI 6:24, 1KI 6:25, 1KI 6:26, 1KI 7:2, 1KI 7:2, 1KI 7:2, 1KI 7:6, 1KI 7:6, 1KI 7:10, 1KI 7:10, 1KI 7:15, 1KI 7:15, 1KI 7:16, 1KI 7:16, 1KI 7:19, 1KI 7:23, 1KI 7:23, 1KI 7:23, 1KI 7:24, 1KI 7:27, 1KI 7:27, 1KI 7:27, 1KI 7:31, 1KI 7:31, 1KI 7:31, 1KI 7:32, 1KI 7:32, 1KI 7:35, 1KI 7:38, 2KI 14:13, 2KI 25:17, 2KI 25:17, 2KI 25:17, 1CH 11:23, 2CH 3:3, 2CH 3:3, 2CH 3:3, 2CH 3:4, 2CH 3:8, 2CH 3:8, 2CH 3:11, 2CH 3:11, 2CH 3:11, 2CH 3:12, 2CH 3:12, 2CH 3:13, 2CH 3:15, 2CH 3:15, 2CH 4:1, 2CH 4:1, 2CH 4:1, 2CH 4:2, 2CH 4:2, 2CH 4:2, 2CH 4:3, 2CH 6:13, 2CH 6:13, 2CH 6:13, 2CH 25:23, NEH 3:13, EST 5:14, EST 7:9, ISA 6:4, JER 51:13, JER 52:21, JER 52:21, JER 52:22, EZK 40:5, EZK 40:5, EZK 40:7, EZK 40:9, EZK 40:9, EZK 40:11, EZK 40:11, EZK 40:12, EZK 40:12, EZK 40:12, EZK 40:12, EZK 40:13, EZK 40:14, EZK 40:15, EZK 40:19, EZK 40:21, EZK 40:21, EZK 40:23, EZK 40:25, EZK 40:25, EZK 40:27, EZK 40:29, EZK 40:29, EZK 40:30, EZK 40:30, EZK 40:33, EZK 40:33, EZK 40:36, EZK 40:36, EZK 40:42, EZK 40:42, EZK 40:42, EZK 40:47, EZK 40:47, EZK 40:48, EZK 40:48, EZK 40:48, EZK 40:48, EZK 40:49, EZK 40:49, EZK 41:1, EZK 41:1, EZK 41:2, EZK 41:2, EZK 41:2, EZK 41:2, EZK 41:2, EZK 41:3, EZK 41:3, EZK 41:3, EZK 41:4, EZK 41:4, EZK 41:5, EZK 41:5, EZK 41:8, EZK 41:9, EZK 41:10, EZK 41:11, EZK 41:12, EZK 41:12, EZK 41:12, EZK 41:13, EZK 41:13, EZK 41:14, EZK 41:15, EZK 41:22, EZK 41:22, EZK 42:2, EZK 42:2, EZK 42:4, EZK 42:4, EZK 42:7, EZK 42:8, EZK 42:8, EZK 42:16, EZK 43:13, EZK 43:13, EZK 43:13, EZK 43:13, EZK 43:13, EZK 43:14, EZK 43:14, EZK 43:14, EZK 43:14, EZK 43:15, EZK 43:17, EZK 43:17, EZK 45:2, EZK 47:3, ZEC 5:2, ZEC 5:2

The *’amah* is the distance from the tip of the elbow to the tip of the middle finger, that is, about 50 centimeters or 18 inches. There is also a longer cubit mentioned in Ezekiel (see *tefach* above, 11.4.1.2 Span<REALIA:11.4.1.2>).

EZK 41:8: The Hebrew text here speaks of an *’amah ’atsilah*. The word *’atsilah* is problematic, perhaps referring to a length, or perhaps having something to do with a foundation or a terrace. Translations generally treat it as a length, something that qualifies the length of a cubit: “a long cubit” (so RSV). Others indicate this by giving a longer length for the rod than someone might expect, for example, “ten and one-half feet” (NCV). If it is felt to be significant that a non-standard cubit is being used here, then this latter solution will be unacceptable.

Gomed

11.4.1.5 Gomed

References:

Hebrew גֹּמֶד (gomed) JDG 3:16

JDG 3:16: This single appearance of the *gomed* gives us little to indicate its length. Many commentators and translations take it to be equal to a cubit. Since Ehud was able to hide the sword under his garment, it probably could not have been any longer than a cubit, and it may have been shorter. CEV translates the Hebrew word *cherev* (usually rendered “sword”) as “dagger,” thus indicating it was short, but leaves the phrase about its length untranslated. Another possible model is “a short … sword” (GECL).

Reed, rod

11.4.1.6 Reed, rod

References:

Hebrew קָנֶה (qaneh) EZK 40:3, EZK 40:5, EZK 40:5, EZK 40:5, EZK 40:6, EZK 40:6, EZK 40:7, EZK 40:7, EZK 40:7, EZK 40:8, EZK 41:8, EZK 42:16, EZK 42:16, EZK 42:16, EZK 42:17, EZK 42:17, EZK 42:18, EZK 42:18, EZK 42:19, EZK 42:19

The *qaneh* in Ezekiel was a measuring rod used to measure length. It had a fixed length of six cubits and a palm, that is, about 3.5 meters (11.5 feet). See also 1.8.6 Measuring rod, measuring line<REALIA:1.8.6>, and "Reed"<FLORA:5.1.4> in *Plants and Trees in the Bible.*